in the space of 11 madcap overs; we were chastened and humiliated.

The daggers and stones were probably being reloaded, but in cricket – as in life – whenever tempted to condemn, it is often wise just to pause for a moment and reserve judgement.

Australia started their second innings and were promptly routed by the swing and seam of Vernon Philander, who was making his Test debut, and Morné Morkel. The mighty Aussies, the renowned battlers in baggy green caps whom we had never beaten in a home Test series since readmission, were reduced to four for one, 11 for two, 13 for three, 13 for four, 15 for five, and then 18 for six, 21 for seven, 21 for eight and 21 for nine.

They were still short of the lowest total in the history of Test cricket (26 scored by New Zealand against England in Auckland in 1955), but their last pair of Peter Siddle and Nathan Lyon ensured they passed that total and batted on, until I caught Lyon off Dale's bowling. Australia had been dismissed for 47.

Batting looked almost impossible and a target of 236 to win seemed a long shot, but Graeme and Hash launched our chase and restored normality. Each scored a century and we won by eight wickets.

The second Test in Johannesburg proved no less exciting.

At first we seemed well set at 241 for four but collapsed to 266 all out. In reply, Phil Hughes and Shane Watson shared an opening stand of 174, but they also lost wickets quickly and were dismissed for 296.

The match was beautifully poised when we started our second innings and, although we teetered for a moment at 90 for three, Hash and I built a partnership and, moving on to 237 for three, appeared on the brink of taking the game away from the tourists, ensuring we could not lose and so securing the series win.

It was all there for the taking and, in all honesty, we should have closed the deal. We didn't. For the second time in the Test, to my intense frustration, I got out when well set, and yet again, the Australians kept battling,